RAJASTHAN

BJP STILL FAR FROM THE MARK

By Rohit Parihar



WOOING CROWDS J.P. Nadda in Sawai Madhopur on April 2

It was supposed to be politics of the peaceful sort: a bit of schmoozing with local party figures, a bit of outreach to influential Scheduled Tribe segments, a soft launch to the campaign for next year's assembly election. But by the time BJP president J.P. Nadda's visit to Sawai Madhopur in east Rajasthan wound up, it had got singed in the flames of the worst flare-up the state has seen in recent times—right next door in Karauli. That went according to the usual script: bracketed between peace meetings on either side, there was a Hindu procession through a Muslim-dominated bazaar, provocative slogans from one side, stone-pelting from the other, arson as a counter, over a dozen shops gutted, some 35 injured, arrests, curfew. It was likely a coincidence that it happened on the same day, April 2. But with both the ruling Congress and the challenger BJP beginning to get into campaign mode 21 months before actual polling, the events have the potential to frame Rajasthan politics in a way that both sides are ambivalent about.

The dilemma is more acute for the BJP. Should it go down the route of hard Hindutva? The temptation is never going to be as acute in Rajasthan as it is in, say, Uttar Pradesh. And it has plenty else to think about. It won't be easy to depose Congress chief minister Ashok Gehlot, who has built up a certain populist armour around himself with a raft of welfare measures. If the BJP is serious about the game, it will first of all need to revisit the question of state leader-

TO DEPOSE GEHLOT, THE BJP WILL HAVE TO DO MORE THAN HINDUTVA. SETTLE ON A LEADER, FOR ONE. VASUNDHARA RAJE IS EN ROUTE

ship in a concerted, honest manner. In 2018, they had gone into the election with open dissension against former CM Vasundhara Raje playing alongside their campaign—and came a cropper. The distance between Raje and the central leadership has reduced considerably since then, but the last mile remains.

The Nadda visit exemplified some of the key dilemmas for the BJP. He was in Sawai Madhopur for a family function, but as the state unit got wind of his presence, they rustled up a programme where he could meet prominent tribal leaders of eastern Rajasthan. The BJP had suffered huge losses in this northern Aravali belt, and remains weak here—so an outreach seemed like a good idea. But the programme fomented trouble from the start. Some leaders asked why the prominent non-tribal faces were not invited, pointing to an essential truth about Rajasthan: inter-caste competition is more intense here than any communal polarisation.

The latter, of course, took over in the aftermath of Karauli, with a war of words between Gehlot and BJP leaders. But there's good reason why it may not last. Communal polarisation doesn't work in Rajasthan. Not because of any innate secularism, but simply because the 9 per cent Muslim population is scattered across vastly isolated pockets. And the community here has a different flavour: many converts from local communities like the Rajputs and an array of backward and tribal groups retain aspects of their native culture, so it offers little space for the stark 'hard Hindutva vs hard Islamist' narrative that can play out with aplomb elsewhere. Even when Muslims do determinedly vote in a certain way, as they did in 2018, it affects scarcely more than half-a-dozen seats in a 200-seat assembly.

It may be better then for the BJP to focus on what it must do to take on Gehlot: pick a worthy, and weighty, face. Some progress has happened on that front. In March-end, Raje was the only state leader invited to the oath-taking ceremonies of the CMs of Uttarakhand and UP. She had a private audience with the PM on March 24 and met with a host of other prominent figures. Political watchers saw it as a sign that the BJP was restoring Raje to clear pre-eminence. However, she did not visit Sawai Madhopur. Perhaps it's time that last bridge is crossed. As a BJP national executive member says, "People will no longer vote in the name of PM Modi, just like they didn't in 2018." ■